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The poetics of practice-based research writing

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Practice-based research invites us to re-examine the relationship between our scholarly arguments and the modes of expression we adopt to communicate them. A choice of genre implies a commitment to the conventions of a particular discourse, its metaphors, analogies and rhetorical strategies. If different genres express (and, arguably, create) different views, what do 'hybrid' forms of writing—writing of uncertain or shifting provenance, such as the prose poem, the poet's critical essay, or the philosophical dialogue—express? What are the consequences of choosing a given mode of expression in research writing? What epistemic assumptions and implications does it carry? What is the relationship between 'critical' and 'creative' writing in practice-based research?

This essay investigates how literary and philosophical genres of inquiry may be applied to research writing.[1] Considering Richard Buchanan's concept of design argument in relation to the practice-based doctorate, this paper argues that the 'hybrid' text is concerned less with resolving problems on the basis of a theory, than with setting the terms by which the problem can be addressed through calculated performances and gestures. Hybrid literary genres, incorporating strategies from creative and critical practices, can thus help us frame the practice-based investigation, refine its methods, and give voice(s) to its research results, thereby equipping designers as well as researchers with important conceptual and representational tools.

> Best would be to think in a form one had invented.
> Paul Valery[2]

> A way of seeing is also a way of not seeing.
> Kenneth Burke[3]

> Painting has nothing to do with thinking, because in painting thinking is painting. Thinking is language—record-keeping—and has to take place before and after. Einstein did not think when he was calculating; he calculated—producing the next equation in reaction to the one that went before—just as in painting one form is a response to another, and so on.
> Gerard Richter[4]

> All serious art, music and literature is a *critical* act. [. . .] Aesthetic means embody concentrated, selective interactions between the constraints of the observed and the boundless possibilities of the imagined. Such formed intensity of sight and of speculative ordering is, always, a critique. It says that things might be (have been, shall be) otherwise.
>
> But literature and the arts are also criticism in a more particular and practical sense. They embody an expository reflection on, a value judgement of, the inheritance and context to which they pertain.
> George Steiner[5]

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Introduction

Architectonic art organises the efforts of other arts and crafts, bringing order, shape and purpose to their modes of production. Architecture has long been identified as an architectonic art, orchestrating the contributions of a broad range of specialised disciplines and practices and rationalising their individual components into a single, coherent product or concept. Thus *architecture* has also become a metaphor for other forms of architectonic organisation (information architecture, computer systems architecture, or the architecture of our infrastructure—electricity grids, transport networks, and communications systems). Research is another form of architectonic practice, as is writing—writing here denoting, if we may momentarily accept the too-convenient distinction, both *creative* and *critical* writing. The term *design* encompasses all such architectonic arts and enables us to cross-pollinate our keywords as required; writing *as* design, design *as* research, research *as* architecture, architecture *as* writing, and so forth. Such hybrid concepts cluster around the relatively recent concept of practice-based research, for reasons which this paper will explore.

The emergence of the field of practice-based research provides us with an opportunity to re-examine the relationship between our scholarly arguments and the modes of expression we adopt to record, represent, and communicate them. As artists, designers, architects and others staking a claim for our practice to be regarded as a form of research, we are obliged to consider the consequences of our chosen mode(s) of expression, its appropriateness to our inquiry, its generic assumptions and its epistemic implications. Such issues resonate far beyond the field of practice-based research itself, raising a number of central questions for the wider scholarly community at a time when the epistemological foundations of knowledge have been shown to be provisional at best, and the terms of verification and falsification, by which we would conventionally distinguish science from non-science, are more than ever open to negotiation. If the conventions of scholarly validation are themselves shown to be historically and culturally circumscribed modes of legitimising belief, can one ever escape the infinite regress of self-validating conventions of logic?

This paper claims that practice-based research is rather more than a recent and currently modish addition to educational jargon; it is a mode of investigation which permits the participating research community to synthesise ever-increasing amounts of explicit and subliminal input, and this obviously has implications for how we represent our research; should we continue to assume that a single, coherent 'authoritative' text is automatically more 'serious' than a series of provisional, tentative remarks or discrete facts presented in the form of a dialogue or narrative? Is a complex, unconventional narrative better suited to exploring the play of conceptual possibilities than a simple conventional one? Can we deploy narrative loose ends—or what Kenneth Burke terms the 'resources of ambiguity' in language—with critical sophistication, subtlety or precision?

Such questions relate to a broader question concerning *practical knowledge*—namely, how do we integrate design theory and practice? The usual answer is by means of a third form of discourse, that of *criticism*. Criticism exists to examine, more

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or less systematically, qualitative *differences* among human artefacts and processes. If we seek to improve such artefacts and processes, and also enrich design discourse, our critical practice must be informed by *method*, so that we can explain why we reason about quality the way we do. Norms for criticism come from a history of systematic reflection about the principles and techniques that guide practice—in other words, *theory*. The traditions of theory would soon wither without some contact with practical reason—practical knowledge, or *phronesis*. Hence our interest in *practice-based research*. Practice, in this context, helps us to refresh the concepts underpinning our research methods and aims.

What is the core concept in practice-based research? I would suggest *communication*—for if this were not the case, practice would remain practice and not additionally a form of research, capable of communicating with a scholarly *as well as* a professional community.[6] Few, however, have fully explored the implications of this for the design disciplines. Design, as Richard Buchanan has argued, is comparable to rhetoric as 'an art of shaping society, changing the course of individuals and communities, and setting patterns for new action.'[7] Yet designers, unlike rhetoricians, typically lack the capacity for critical evaluation of design practices. This is perhaps an example of 'trained incapacity'—the deliberately incongruous term that Kenneth Burke uses to convey the idea that any way of seeing, as he argues in *Language as Symbolic Action*, is also a way of not seeing. A professional trains him or herself to view the world through a certain set of assumptions, and thereby necessarily filters out other interpretations. One result of this is that judgements (of quality, methodology and purpose, for example) are too often left to patrons and/or professional critics, thereby obstructing the development of professional and public discourse on contemporary design practice. Thus the basis and validation of *judgement* becomes a particularly urgent problem in design, as elsewhere. Harold Brown has surveyed the history of one of epistemology's core problems—namely, the threat of an infinite regress that appears when we try to understand what counts as a justification for some belief. The problem, he writes, goes back at least as far as the *Theaetetus* where Plato rejects the account of knowledge as justified true belief because a justification that will yield knowledge requires that the justifiers themselves be known, and this raises the question of whether these justifiers are themselves justified. In the *Theaetetus* Plato provides no account of how we might avoid the resulting regress and Brown illustrates how this has led to *foundational epistemologies* in which the regress ends only with some set of propositions that are supposed to be self-evident, and thus not in need of further justification.[8]

Individual and/or collective judgements shape the entire process of inquiry (rather than rules as the positivists had assumed)—and it is no longer controversial to claim that good scholarship today involves far more than fact and logic (nor that what we designate as fact or logic are themselves socially constructed). In his introduction to a collection of interdisciplinary perspectives on 'The Rhetorical Turn' in contemporary theory, Herbert Simons writes of Method being replaced by 'variable,

creative, non-algorithmic' methods, of generalised laws being displaced by 'contingent, historically situated truths, reflective of values and interests, and found more or less useful by cultures and communities which are themselves symbolically constituted.' Furthermore, he writes:

> there are faint suspicions that scholarly communities are no less influenced by 'fuzzy' logics than by formal, deductive, 'closed-fisted' logics: by arguments from sign and analogy, by anecdotes and exemplars; and even by appeals to authority, tradition, convention, intuition and aesthetic goodness-of-fit.[9]

It may be that practice-based research similarly acknowledges alternative, competing or even contradictory belief systems that nonetheless somehow organise diverse and variable (culturally, professionally and historically) conceptions of reason. In this sense, practice-based research may serve not merely to deconstruct systems of logic which depend on a process of self-validation for their support, but also to reconstruct the question of how we might investigate, make reasonable comparisons, judgements and evaluations, and use language in contexts where there can exist no 'proof' as such. If this is so, the need to explore forms of argument appropriate to identifying and representing the elements of our practice, and the expressions of our shared and changing professional knowledge, becomes for practice-based researchers a central challenge, if not *the* central challenge. Accordingly, what I propose here (from the admittedly logocentric perspective of a writer and scholar originally trained in the study of literature) is an account of practice-based research as an architectonic strategy for inventing and organising discourses about cultural production in a way that such discourses are inter-woven with social, political and moral discourses.

Practice-based research as rhetorical argument

Owing to the increasing importance of technology, combined with the increasing distance between technologists and designers, Richard Buchanan has claimed that 'a unifying theory of rhetoric' is needed more than ever in design, a theory in which 'technology is viewed fundamentally as a rhetorical problem, integrated within the perspective of a broader design art' and in which 'the puzzling diversity of design communication as we encounter it in everyday products is made more intelligible, providing the basis for better public criticism and evaluation of design.'[10] If technology is concerned with the probable rather than the necessary, Buchanan continues (or with the contingencies of practical use and action, rather than the certainties of scientific principle), then technology becomes rhetorical in 'a startling fashion'—it becomes 'an art of deliberation about the issues of practical action', one which is 'fundamentally concerned with a form of persuasion and, as with traditional rhetoric, speaks from no special authority about the good life. It provides only resources that are used to support a variety of arguments about practical living, reflecting different ideas and viewpoints on social life.'[11] Buchanan next gives an account of design from the perspective of a discipline similarly informed by rhetorical concepts and, potentially, methods:

> Design is an art of thought directed to practical action through the persuasiveness of objects

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and, therefore, design involves the vivid expression of competing ideas about social life.[12] Thus the designer is the person who creates 'a persuasive argument that comes to life whenever a user considers or uses a product as a means to some end.'[13] Such an account has obvious relevance to our inquiry into the role(s) of writing in (or *as*) practice-based research.

Applying terms from classical rhetoric, Buchanan defines design argument as comprising three elements: the *logos* or technological reasoning (the core of the argument, he claims); the *ethos* or 'character' of an object; and its emotional quality, or *pathos*. These elements do not operate independently of each other—designers tend to draw on all three elements in any design project—but they do allow us to distinguish the different elements of a design argument. Technological reasoning here essentially denotes 'the way the designer manipulates materials and processes to solve practical problems of human activity' and is also 'based on premises drawn from human circumstances, that is, from the attitudes and values of potential users and the physical conditions of actual use.'[14] (The persuasive success of the artefact will be evaluated by its effectiveness in addressing the needs for which it was designed; spoons, for example, generally adhere to the same design premises and forms since their purpose is to transport the contents of a container or bowl to another container or mouth, while being held in the hand.) Character or *ethos* refers to the designed artefact's 'voice' or style—its capacity to suggest a lifestyle or set of values (which the user and the designer implicitly share) such as common sense, virtue, modernity, goodwill, authoritativeness, or flamboyance. Emotion or *pathos*, the third element of design argument, arises (according to Buchanan) from 'physical contact with objects or from active contemplation of objects before, during, and after use.'[15] The experience of movement when using or contemplating an object can particularly strongly convey its capacity to touch us emotionally, and the persuasive power of the emotional argument of a design thus can be said to be linked to its capacity to diminish the distance between the object and the user's feelings, prompting the user emotionally to identify with the object—to be moved by it while moving it in turn. I will return to this tri-partite division of the elements of design argument shortly.

Christopher Frayling's 1993 paper *Research in Art and Design* adopts three different prepositions to denote different relationships between research and design. Research *for* design is generally applied to investigations oriented towards a design application; research *into* design denotes historical and theoretical studies of design; whereas research *through* design regards design processes as constituting the research methodology itself, or at least the greater part thereof.[16] This latter category is what we usually have in mind when using terms such as *practice-based* research, *practice-led* research and so forth.[17] A subsequent (1997) document—the UK Council for Graduate Education report—characterises practice-based research as follows:

> [T]he *practice-based doctorate* advances knowledge partly *by means of practice*. An original/creative piece of work is included in the submission for examination. It is distinct in that

> significant aspects of the claim for doctoral characteristics of originality, mastery and contribution to the field are held to be demonstrated through the original creative work.
>
> Practice-based doctoral submissions must include a substantial *contextualization of the creative work*. This critical appraisal or analysis not only clarifies the basis of the claim for the originality and location of the original work, it also provides the basis for a judgment as to whether *general scholarly requirements* are met. This could be defined as judgment of the submission as a contribution to knowledge in the field, showing doctoral level powers of analysis and mastery of existing contextual knowledge, in a form which is accessible to and auditable by knowledgeable peers.[18]

The candidate is thus obliged to adopt a double role of 'making' and 'assessing' her/his work. This assessment requires the work to be positioned within the history of a field, the (discursive) articulation of its relationship to previous and contemporaneous works in the field, the identification of issues at stake, of questions being posed, problems being addressed, and of what answers are being suggested by the work in question.[19]

Such emphasis on a 'substantial' critical appraisal, analysis or *contextualisation of the creative work* indicates that the rhetorical argument remains an important feature of the practice-based doctorate, as in the conventional doctorate. In fact, the same elements used by Buchanan to discuss rhetoric, argument, and demonstration in design practice—ie, *logos*, or reasoning, *ethos*, or 'character', and *pathos* or emotion—may help focus our study of how we *investigate*, *research* and *report* on design. Yet existing studies of the role of the written text in practice-based research tend to highlight the potentially antagonistic relationship between artistic practice and the requirement to provide a written account of such practice.[20] Writing is thus implicitly assumed to provide a scholarly account or theorisation of practice—in effect, an extended caption to (and apologia for) the more important artistic artefact or process. To my knowledge, few have considered the written text's capacity to interrogate, as well as represent, practice-based research. It is as if the stylistic pretence of an absence of literary style is so established that few wish to acknowledge the implications of Derrida's observation that '[a] philosophical debate is also a combat in view of imposing discursive modes, demonstrative procedures, rhetorical and pedagogical techniques. Each time philosophy has been opposed, it was also, although not only, by contesting the properly, authentically philosophical character of the other's discourse.'[21] But a focus on the relationship between philosophical and literary modes of writing allows us to identify some of the rhetorical characteristics of philosophical inquiry and to discern how these shape relationships to readers and the formation of descriptions and pictures of the world. Such an examination is long overdue, as Berel explains:

> Although the history of western philosophy is almost entirely a history of written texts, philosophers have lived in that history—and written and thought in it—as if the role of the unusual artefacts we recognize as manuscripts and books were entirely incidental. The assumption here is

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> that the act of writing has nothing—at least nothing *essential*—to do with the act of philosophy; that philosophy as spoken, 'oral' philosophy, would have the same character that written or 'literary' philosophy does, and that the two of them would be identical to philosophy as it might be thought but not yet expressed, or even to philosophy in its hidden truth before it had been thought at all. The conventional means of writing, in other words—of syntax and of language—have no more to do with *what* is written than do the further literary possibilities exemplified by individual style with *its* marks of the author's voice. All that counts philosophically in this view of the history of philosophy—past or future—is the 'what' which is asserted there, not the 'how' by means of which the 'what' puts in an appearance.[22]

In literary writing, such characteristics include specific sensory details, anecdotes and examples, characterisation and personification, story and suspense; whereas in scientific texts they typically involve abstract, impersonal, 'disembodied' and schematic articulations of positions. But if we consider the distinction between 'creative' and 'critical' practices as one of role-playing—of the capacity to shift positions at will—writing expertise consists in moving between creative and critical writing conventions, genres and strategies as required by the specific design or research project. This means that one is able to *choose* one's 'way of seeing' instead of being ensnared within a relatively narrow range of culturally legitimised perspectives and discourses. In regard to this latter point, Jenny Wolmark and Eleanor Gates-Stuart advocate that we should consider research not as a codified form of academic inquiry but rather as

> . . . a cultural practice that is generated by and through the intersection with other cultural practices and that knowledge can therefore be understood as 'situated' . . . Situated knowledge is no longer decontextualized and removed from the social and cultural relations in which it is embedded.[23]

We can explore situated knowledge and identify forms of practice that demand more than the formal properties of reason alone by appropriating strategies, methods and concepts from other discursive regimes, such as that of literature. Literary concepts and rhetorical practices can furnish the practical as well as conceptual tools required to become not merely better scholars and critics, but also, as I have argued elsewhere,[24] better designers. This account of writing—both research writing and exploratory or so-called 'creative' writing—therefore positions writing as an essential tool for practice-based research. As such, far from being antagonistic to the practical (or 'tacit') knowledge of artists, architects, engineers and designers, writing—critically *and* creatively conceived—assumes an integral role within practice-based research. One important aspect of this concerns the capacity of literary and philosophical writing to influence and extend our way of seeing the world. Here, in passing, is how the philosopher and novelist Alain de Botton responds to a detail in Proust's characterisation of the fictional Duchesse de Guermantes:

> We might have felt there was something superior and insolent in this woman's manner without knowing quite what, until Proust discreetly

points out in brackets how the Duchesse reacts when, during a smart dinner, a Mme de Gallardon makes the error of being a little overfamiliar with the Duchesse, known also as Oriane des Laumes, and addresses her by her first name.

> 'Oriane' (at once Mme de Laumes looked with amused astonishment towards an invisible third person, whom she seemed to call to witness that she had never authorized Mme de Gallardon to use her Christian name)...

An effect of reading a book [de Botton continues] which has devoted attention to noticing such faint yet vital tremors is that, once we've put the volume down and resumed our own life, we may attend to precisely the things which the author would have responded to had he or she been in our company. Our mind will be like a radar newly attuned to pick up certain objects floating through consciousness, the effect will be like bringing a radio into a room that we had thought silent, and realizing that the silence only existed at a particular frequency and that all along we in fact shared the room with waves of sound coming in from a Ukrainian station or the night-time chatter of a minicab firm. Our attention will be drawn to the shades of the sky, to the changeability of a face, to the hypocrisy of a friend, or to a submerged sadness about a situation which we had previously not even known we could feel sad about.[25]

It is this 'noticing an aspect' that spans design practice and research. As Thomas Kuhn has shown, for science to advance, emerging scientists must acquire not merely a methodology but also a 'way of seeing'—an ability, that is, to identify the salient features of a problem situation and evaluate their significance in the appropriate context. What is acquired is the ability directly to discern the parameters of a situation in a manner analogous to what is involved in the appreciation of a work of art. Kuhn's analysis of the role of 'exemplars' in effective scientific problem-solving[26] illustrates the centrality of reliable judgement, acquired through practice, to scientific inquiry and research. Trained judgement involves the ability to recognise the relevant features in a situation, the appropriate combination of operative factors and patterns, their harmony or disharmony, and the weight they should have in a particular context. This 'way of seeing' is thus a skilled performance achieved only after exposure to a range of problems and the types of strategies employed for their resolution. It shares much in common with the Aristotelian notion of *phronesis* (practical wisdom); like *phronesis*, it is acquired through training and practice, and the development of a given level of skill creates the conditions for still more skilled performances in the future. And as practical wisdom becomes second nature to the *phronimos*, so good judgement—an essential attribute of a successful designer and researcher—becomes second nature, or so we hope, to the person who can reason in an innovative and useful manner.

An interest in the phenomenon of 'seeing-as', of recognition, insight, or seeing connections, invites a comparison of Wittgenstein's late philosophical work, which borders on the literary and aphoristic, staging on the page an internalised, seemingly irreconcilable philosophical dialogue, to the paradoxical literary genre of the prose poem. The prose

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poem and the philosophical dialogue are both compelling and highly complex literary forms for modelling argument. Neither poetry nor prose, the prose poem shapes critical as well as literary language by staging shifting points of view, changing perspectives, empathetic as well as analytical forms of understanding, narration, 'voice', suspense, plot, inter-textual citation, and far more. Philosophers, researchers and designers can learn much from close reading and discussion of a textual artefact such as a prose poem, or the dramatisation of perspectives in philosophical writing such as that of Wittgenstein's *Philosophical Investigations*.[27] These are essentially *dialogical* genres, although the status and effect of the dialogical will obviously differ across diverse prose poems and philosophical dialogues, as well as between the two forms themselves. It is not my purpose to undertake such a survey, or comparison, here.

For the practice-based researcher, the skills involved in 'close reading' can yield not merely a broader range of writing and representational techniques, but can heighten critical sensitivity. Katja Grillner claims that to experiment and explore different modes of writing may be 'one of the most crucial ingredients in the development of research by design', affecting 'what we may in fact both think and communicate', offering tools to develop 'critical counterpoints' to one's own reasoning, and allowing us to 'jump between positions' by incorporating the role of the critic into our own project(s). This, she claims, is 'an essential requirement' for *research* projects in contrast to other art or architecture projects:

> a research project *must*, in some way, open up to discursive encounters. By developing a critical perspective on her or his work, the author/architect behind a project invites others to participate, not in awe, but in critical discussion.[28]

The notion of critical counterpoints is also identified by the Czech novelist and essayist Milan Kundera as an integral feature of the novel. He uses a musical term—that of *polyphony*—in his analogy:

> Polyphony in music is the *simultaneous* presentation of two or more voices (melodic lines) that are perfectly bound together but still keep their relative independence. And polyphony in the novel? First let's set out its opposite: *unilinear* composition. Now, since its very beginnings, the novel has always tried to escape the unilinear, to open rifts in the continual narration of the story. Cervantes tells the story of Don Quixote's journey, which is quite linear. But as he travels, Quixote meets other characters who tell their own stories. In the first part there are four such. Four rifts that allow us to step outside the novel's linear framework. [. . .] You'll see that it's not so farfetched to compare the novel to music. Indeed, one of the fundamental principles of the great polyphonic composers was the *equality of voices*: no one voice should dominate, none should serve as mere accompaniment. [. . .] Now, to my mind, the conditions *sine qua non* for counterpoint in the novel are: first, the equality of the various 'lines', and second, the indivisibility of the whole.[29]

The development of any field of research or professional practice involves privileging particular cultural metaphors and analogies, references and

examples, and, in the process, cross-pollinating, hybridising (or repressing) existing assumptions and methodologies.[30] Reductive thinking, critical analysis, inspiration, poetry, innovation—each form of cultural production marshals its own set of diverse inputs to discern connections where none were perceived previously. Text-generating games and techniques such as *The Exquisite Corpse* of the Surrealists as well as comparable experiments from Dada and Oulipo artists, explicitly targeted language's capacities to throw up connections. Such autopoietic strategies are a response to the apparently limitless resources of language that George Steiner describes:

> We can say any truth and any falsehood. We can affirm and negate in the same breath. We can construe material impossibility at will; in the Hegelian dialectic man 'falls up'. Thus language itself possesses and is possessed by the dynamics of fiction. To speak, either to oneself or to another, is in the most naked, rigorous sense of that unfathomable banality, to invent, to re-invent being and the world. Voiced truth is, ontologically and logically, 'true fiction', where the etymology of fiction directs us immediately to that of 'making'.[31]

This very open-endedness has fuelled the meta-theoretical energies of deconstruction as it investigates and critiques all available theories of meaning and models of understanding. But in a constructive rather than deconstructive mode, the same sense of boundless freedom in language, and writing particularly, also places particular emphasis on our capacity to discern connections across diverse discourses, changing language games, shape-shifting input, and non-linguistic data. This is particularly the case in contemporary contexts of increasingly interdisciplinary or even *a-disciplinary* or *post-disciplinary* ways of working. The many convergences taking place today—between biology, technology and art, for example, or interdisciplinarity and complexity—belong to a wider crossing of cultural, national, and political boundaries, all of which contribute, as Julie Thompson Klein argues, to reversing 'the differentiating, classificatory dynamic of modernity and increasing hybridization of cultural categories, identities, and previous certainties. [. . .] All cultural categories, identities, and certainties have undergone de-differentiation, de-insulation, and hybridization. All boundaries are at risk.'[32] Since there are as a result a growing number of problems 'without a discipline', this skill in *seeing connections*—a skill that fuses creative and critical modes of inquiry (or curiosity)—will become increasingly important. Poetry, we can say, is spun across rapidly changing conditions of perception and reception; as such, it is *the* art for representing the dynamics of (seeing/saying/staging) connections *par excellence*. But philosophers such as Wittgenstein—who once famously remarked that philosophy ought only to be written as poetic composition and whose work stages or *performs* philosophical problems—also sought 'just that understanding which consists in "seeing connections."'[33] He described Freud's work, approvingly, as comprising 'all excellent similes'[34] and said something similar of his own work in philosophy: 'What I invent are new *similes*.'[35] Cognitive science, in its attempts to plot the basic cognitive processes and structures that give rise to all forms of creativity,

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has identified 'conceptual combination' as a process highly conducive to creativity. This comprises juxtaposing two or more concepts to create a new conceptual whole with unforeseen, emergent properties.[36] The philosophical dialogue can be said to operate in a similar way.

Words, for Wittgenstein, make clearings in our overcrowded thoughts, a strategy reminiscent of Schlegel's remark 'The empty place that a garland of fragments surrounds is a precise drawing of the contours of the Work.'[37] What makes Wittgenstein relevant to our interest in practice-based research is this very philosophy *through* language design—an approach that takes a patient uncovering of the workings of language games to constitute philosophy itself, just as research *through* design takes design processes as constitutive of the research methodology itself. And so the *form* of *Philosophical Investigations*, like the paradoxical genre of the prose poem, calls into question our traditional notion of a 'work' as it is here that Wittgenstein examines language as an ensemble of strategies. Fredric Jameson argues that genres are 'essentially literary *institutions*, or social contracts between a writer and a specific public, whose function is to specify the proper use of a particular cultural artefact.'[38] Both the prose poem and the philosophical dialogue would seem to offer a rather unusual contract in this respect—'a contract that seeks to dismantle the very principles of exclusion and property on which contractual agreements—and other literary genres—are based.'[39]

What I am trying to outline is a hybrid genre, a monstrous fusion of creative and critical strategies, a form perhaps of *poetic research*, but, if so, one in which the poetic operates dynamically, at the level of inquiry, and not merely as a way of rendering its subsequent representation decorative or aesthetically palatable. Such a hybrid genre will exhibit a simultaneous *love for* and *distrust of* language, seeking not to embellish what can be said more simply, but to find the most direct, straightforward way of saying something complex. If this requires that sentences occasionally sing and dance, then this is the price of keeping language usable and audible for an often-jaded readership. Similarly, if we lose our capacity to be surprised, to be taken aback, to be astonished (with all the reversals of expectations this implies), we have no means of escaping the monotonous repetition of our disciplinary and discursive heritage. If it is curiosity that drives our investigations, it is surely our capacity for *astonishment* that brings about change in the dawning of an aspect:

> A simile that has been absorbed into the forms of our language produces a false appearance and this disquiets us.
>
> A *picture* held us captive. And we could not get outside it, for it lay in our language and language seemed to repeat it to us inexorably.[40]

A picture holds us captive—and, momentarily, we cannot escape it. We can find astonishment in philosophy, of course, but art—and, specifically, poetry—is particularly attuned to catching us off guard:

> To defend poetry means to defend a fundamental gift of human nature, that is, our capacity … to experience astonishment and to stop still in that astonishment for an extended moment or two.[41]

Consider in this respect the Russian poet Osip Mandelstam's account of Dante's 'thinking in images'

with the aid of 'a peculiarity of poetic material which I propose to call its convertibility or transmutability.' Mandelstam's critical method is illuminating—it begins with an invitation (similar to the invitations to 'Consider this. . . Imagine that. . .' that we find in Wittgenstein's writing):

> Just imagine an airplane (ignoring the technical impossibility) which in full flight constructs and launches another machine. Furthermore, in the same way, this flying machine, while fully absorbed in its own flight, still manages to assemble and launch yet a third machine. To make my proposed comparison more precise and helpful, I will add that the production and launching of these technically unthinkable new machines which are tossed off in mid-flight are not secondary or extraneous functions of the plane which is in motion, but rather comprise a most essential attribute and part of the flight itself, while assuring its feasibility and safety to no less a degree than its properly operating rudder or the regular functioning of its engine.[42]

This is an extraordinary analogy which cheerfully defies possibility and the technically 'thinkable' to describe the 'continuous transformation of the substratum of poetic material, which preserves its unity and aspires to pierce its own internal self.'[43] It is also an astonishing response to astonishment (Mandelstam's, on reading Dante closely, repeatedly), the articulation of which inspires astonishment in Mandelstam's reader and thereby does not merely describe but reproduce poetically what Mandelstam has identified critically. Both critical and imaginative faculties are called into action; the reader *experiences* the point being made, which becomes all the more compelling as a result.

> 564. Now when the aspect dawns, can I separate a visual experience from a thought-experience?—If you separate them the dawning of the aspect seems to vanish.
>
> 565. I think it could also be put this way: *Astonishment* is essential to a change of aspect. And astonishment is thinking.[44]

Can we create conditions favourable to astonishment? This is a task for literature—particularly poetry, as mentioned. But Wittgenstein's emphasis on knowledge as something—startlingly—*animal* in *On Certainty* illustrates his aim to 'dissolve' philosophical metaphysical problems on the basis of alternative representations:

> I want to regard man [*sic*] here as an animal; as a primitive being to which one grants instinct but not ratiocination. As a creature in a primitive state. Any logic good enough for a primitive means of communication needs no apology from us. Language did not emerge from some kind of ratiocination.[45]

When we compare these alternative representations, we gain insight into what we might call the 'grammar' of concepts.[46] I will end with a brief discussion of a single sentence that seems to have some bearing on the animality of knowledge (potentially a far more radical concept than what we previously referred to as the situated nature of knowledge):

> *Leoparden In Tempel*
>
> Leoparden brechen in den Tempel ein und saufen die Opferkrüge leer; das wiederholt sich immer wieder; schließlich kann man es vorausberechnen, und es wird ein Teil der Zeremonie.

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Leopards in the Temple

> Leopards break into the temple and drink to the dregs what is in the sacrificial pitchers; this is repeated over and over again; finally it can be calculated in advance, and it becomes a part of the ceremony.[47]

How should we discuss this enigmatic text by Franz Kafka? We might, for example, consider the parable (or anti-parable) from the point of view of its treatment of *time* and wonder at how a narrative of a single sentence can compact all temporal possibilities as it moves from an implied infinite past (the temples standing unmolested since time immemorial) to an immediate present (the sudden irruption of the leopards, which is also the beginning of the narrative itself), thence to a ritualised, repetitive present of the ongoing breaking in and drinking the contents of the sacrificial pitchers, and so to the future (the calculation of the leopard's arrival) and thence to an ongoing, infinite, ritualised future ('it becomes a part of the ceremony'). We can equally discuss the treatment of *space* in the piece, the dialectic of inside/outside, contained/uncontained, stasis/action, self/other. Or we can explore the question of *agency*—what motivates these events? Who or what is the determining force responsible for transforming *difference* into mere *repetition*?—and that might prompt reflection on the question of the curiously disembodied and impersonal *voice* in the text (Who speaks? To whom? At what distance? With what motivations?), a voice which reports outlandish events as if dispassionately reciting a series of observed occurrences (a tone not unlike that of a cooking recipe or technical manual). Where and when do these events take place? Why is the author apparently uninterested in geography, climate, atmosphere, history and causality? And then there are the afore-mentioned themes of *repetition* and *ritual* to consider—in fact, there would appear to be as many possible readings as there are occasions to discuss the work.

I have discussed this piece with many different readers—with prisoners serving life sentences, designers and engineers, architects and actors, medical professionals, school children, the unemployed and university literature students. What is read variously as an account of incarceration, divorce, innovation, professional responsibility, the anxiety of influence, the danger of letting wild animals roam free, boredom and carnival is, of course, all these and more, but its logic is such that it cannot be reasonably exhausted by our interpretative zeal. Like Kafka's story *In the Penal Colony*, 'Leopards in the Temple' is a machine for enforcing the illegibility and provisionality of interpretation. And this need not be a tragic outcome. The English psychoanalyst Adam Phillips remarks of this piece:

> The dream-like parable, deliberately exempt from psychological explanation, makes us wonder: Are the leopards incorporated in the ceremony out of terror (the people making a virtue of necessity and complying), or out of resignation (the people taking the line of least resistance), or out of wonder (the people being provoked into fortuitous discoveries)?

He leaves the question unanswered, but notes that it is not only the ceremony which is changed: 'we also begin to see the leopards differently once we calculate upon their participation.' [48]

We might similarly examine the role of *participation* when considering the contribution practice can make to research. The practitioner-critic who engages actively with the struggle to achieve form is more likely to be sensitive to the achievements of others working with similar materials. So 'Leopards in the Temple' in the context of our discussion of hybrid genres in practice-led research, seems to suggest something about the dynamics of disruption, dislocation, ritualised anticipation, and finally incorporation and appropriation. It is possibly the story of the formation, fragmentation and reformulation of disciplines, with each new challenge to disciplinary identity and coherence being first an assault, then repeated, tested iteratively at conferences and in publications until finally reaching critical mass whereupon it becomes 'part of the ceremony.' Does this process repress or validate the conditions in which creativity and difference can flourish? Is it the inverse of the term *emergence*, which is used to denote unexpected changes or divergences in complex systems?[49] Such questions will have to be taken up elsewhere.

This paper has argued for 'impure' or hybrid genres, for research not to ignore the realm of the senses, for embodied and experienced and sensual and situated, rather than abstracted, critical positions. Linear argumentation is an inadequate model for those pursuing architectonic investigations. Metaphor, like *form* (as Derrida argues in *Writing and Difference)*, is never innocent, but rather orients research and fixes results:

> *Form* fascinates when one no longer has the force to understand force from within itself. That is, to create. [. . .] Criticism has not always known this, but understands it now, and thus is in the process of thinking itself in its own concept, system and method. Criticism henceforth knows itself separated from force, occasionally avenging itself on force by gravely and profoundly proving that separation is the condition of the work, and not only of the discourse of the work.[50]

If practice-based research writing is to be a tool of discovery or a performance of inquiry, rather than a ritualised repetition of established generic conventions, metaphor and form may appropriately be architectonic, unpredictable, dialogic, polyphonic, animal, monstrous even—in short, structured according to a different model of argumentation, one which unsettles critical convention and authorial intention alike. Research is concerned with difference—a state of affairs, a situation, or our relationship to a particular concept, or family of concepts, is changed through undertaking, understanding, or applying research. Within research, metaphor can subvert cultural and aesthetic expectations, unravel expected results, become, in Gregory Bateson's phrase, *the difference that makes the difference*. Metaphor repeatedly breaks into the temple of stable meaning (which, as we know, is an ideological construct based on consensus) and drinks to the dregs what it finds there while somehow resisting being incorporated into the ceremony. We see this in profoundly architectonic work such as that of Walter Benjamin's *Arcades Project*, in truly unsettling dialogues such as Denis Diderot's *Rameau's Nephew* or Mikhail Bakhtin's notion of 'double-voiced discourse',[51] or in creative-critical work such as Coleridge's writing on Shakespeare, Angela Carter's critically astute fiction, the unique prose genre—by turns poetic, philosophical, meditative

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and narrative—invented by Edmund Jabes, W.G. Sebald's genre-bending novels (themselves the product, as Sebald once said of literature in general, of 'hard work' and 'airy magic'), or Osip Mandelstam's 'Conversation about Dante' which fuse poet and critic, practitioner and theorist, visionary and technician, so seamlessly, brilliantly, and insightfully that all such reductive binary oppositions dissolve under the fierce heat of the inquiring intelligence.

Such work invites us to replace conventional distinctions between the creative and critical (or perhaps design-led research and research-led design) through a conscious redrafting of generic and disciplinary boundaries. Literature can thus not only forge practical conceptual and reflective tools for designers, writers and researchers, but also inspire us all by reminding us that in work, as in play, it is our unchanging duty (if we are to drink to the dregs what is in the sacrificial pitchers) to seek greater imaginative and intellectual freedom while making ever-greater demands on the tools and materials of our professions, so that we may usefully share such freedom with others.

Notes and references

1. This paper develops a keynote lecture I gave at a conference entitled *The Unthinkable Doctorate* organised by Hogeschool Voor Wetenschap & Kunst/Sint-Lucas Architectuur Brussel-Gent/NETHCA, Brussels, 14th–16th April, 2005. I wish to express my gratitude to Marc Belderbos for the invitation and to Johan Verbeke, Dean of Sint-Lucas School of Architecture, and the organising committee for their warm welcome and hospitality. I would also like to express my thanks to Hilde Heynen for her critical engagement with the original presentation and encouragement to develop the paper further.
2. Paul Valéry, *Rhumbs*, vol. 2, in *Oeuvres* (Paris, Bibliotheque de la Pléiade, 1962), p. 649.
3. Kenneth Burke, *Language as Symbolic Action* (University of California Press,1966).
4. Gerhardt Richter, 'Extracts from writings and interviews', in Iwona Blazwick and Janna Graham, eds, *Gerhardt Richter: Atlas the Reader* (London, Whitechapel Art Gallery, 2004), pp. 17–36.
5. George Steiner, *Real Presences* (London, Faber & Faber, 1989).
6. Communication is here understood, after Buchanan, not in accordance with semiotic or grammatical theories of communication, nor dialectical theories that treat communication in relation to an economic or spiritual truth, but in the context of rhetoric—ie, 'the inventive and persuasive relation of speakers and audiences as they are brought together in speeches or other objects of communication', Richard Buchanan, 'Declaration by Design: Rhetoric, Argument, and Demonstration in Design Practice', in Victor Margolin, ed., *Design Discourse: History, Theory, Criticism* (Chicago and London, University of Chicago Press,1989), p. 91.
7. *Ibid.*, p. 93.
8. See Harold I. Brown, *Rationality* (New York, Routledge, 1988), Chapter 2.
9. Herbert Simons, 'Rhetoric of Inquiry as an Intellectual Movement', in Herbert Simons, ed., *The Rhetorical Turn: Invention and Persuasion in the Conduct of Inquiry* (Chicago and London, University of Chicago Press, 1990).
10. Richard Buchanan, *op. cit.*, (1989), p. 92.
11. *Ibid.*, p. 94.
12. *Ibid.*, p. 94.

13. *Ibid*., p. 96.
14. *Ibid.*, p. 96.
15. *Ibid*., p. 103.
16. Christopher Frayling, *Research in Art and Design* (London, Royal College of Art Research Papers, 1993), Vol.1, No. 1, pp. 1–5.
17. See also Michael A. R. Biggs, 'The Rhetoric of Research', in D. Durling and J. Shackleton, eds, *Common Ground*, Proceedings of the Design Research Society International Conference at Brunel University (Stoke-on-Trent, UK: Staffordshire University Press, 2002), pp. 111–118.
18. Christopher Frayling (chairman), *Practice-Based Doctorates in the Creative and Performing Arts and Design* (Warwick, UK Council for Graduate Education/ CEDAR, University of Warwick, 1997), p. 14.
19. My own doctorate—the first of its kind to be funded by the British Academy—was entitled 'PhD in Creative and Critical Writing', obtained at the University of East Anglia (Norwich, University of East Anglia, 1994). The main part of the thesis (approximately 60, 000 words) was required be an original novel and the accompanying thesis should explain why the novel represents 'a significant departure from existing achievements within the genre.'
20. See, for example, Katy MacLeod 'The Functions of the Written Text in Practice Based PhD Submissions', available online as part of the *Working Papers in Art and Design* at: http://www.herts.ac.uk/artdes1/research/papers/wpades/vol1/macleod1.html
21. In: *Points . . . Interviews, 1974–1994*, ed., E. Weber, trs., P. Kamuf and others (Stanford, Stanford University Press, 1995), p. 219.
22. Berel Lang, *The Anatomy of Philosophical Style* (Oxford, Basil Blackwell Ltd, 1990), p. 11.
23. See Wolmark and Gates-Stuart, 'Research as Cultural Practice', in Working Papers in Art and Design (2002). Available online at www.artdes.herts.ac.uk/res2prac/ (Accessed 15th May, 2006.)
24. See, for example, 'The Performance of Uncertainty: Oppositional Metaphor and the Adversarial Tradition', in Rolf Hughes and John Monks, eds, (1998, 2003), 'Hybrid Genres: *Philosophical Investigations* and the Prose Poem', in John Monk and Rolf Hughes, eds, (2003), 'The Hybrid Muse: Creative and Critical Writing in/as Practice-Based Research', in *The Unthinkable Doctorate* (Sint-Lucas School of Architecture, Conference proceedings, forthcoming, 2006).
25. Alain de Botton, 'On Writing (and Trouts)', in *On Seeing and Noticing* (London, Penguin Books, 2005), pp. 50–51.
26. See Thomas Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 1996) (3rd edition: originally published 1962), pp. 187–91.
27. Wittgenstein repeatedly illustrates how our philosophical problems are rooted in a failure to grasp the workings of language; his attempt to *shift* our thinking required therefore a conscious experiment in the conventions of philosophical expository *form*. This experiment included the adoption of extra-discursive forms, the dialogue form as well as the conventional expository forms of the philosophical tradition. His writing became fragmented, provisional, self-interrogating and he repeated the same or similar examples over and over again, perhaps as a way of approaching a particular problem from a range of different perspectives (arguably, the transfer of knowledge between master and apprentice similarly depends on repetition of examples from an acknowledged repertoire). His Preface to the *Philosophical Investigations* (effectively, a disclaimer) provides an illuminating account of this strenuous search for an appropriate *form* and represents a dramatic departure from philosophical convention. Wittgenstein himself understands that his mode of investigation cannot

have a beginning, middle, and end, nor can it enjoy organic unity, a causal, logical, or sequential structure, an underlying theme or master plot. Instead the book is built on 'sudden change, jumping from one topic to another.' He describes his approach in very practical terms—he speaks of his attempts to 'weld' his notes together and then describes his writings as the 'sketches' of 'a weak draughtsman' which sometimes had to be 'arranged' and sometimes 'cut down, so that if you looked at them you could get a picture of the landscape.' Wittgenstein thus constantly shapes the abstract and makes it concrete. The pedagogical paradox is that Wittgenstein wants his readers to practise certain habits of thought, to exercise certain philosophical skills, but also knows that skills cannot be learned from the page because they cannot be described literally, although description and repetition do play important roles in reminding the apprentice which different stages must be mastered before the skill itself is mastered.

28. Katja Grillner, *Writing and landscape—setting scenes for critical reflection*, in *The Journal of Architecture*, Volume 8 (London, Routledge, 2003), p. 246.
29. Milan Kundera, 'Dialogue on the Art of Composition', from *The Art of the Novel* (Faber & Faber, London, 1988), pp. 73–76.
30. See Rolf Hughes and John Monks, eds, *The Book of Models: Ceremonies, Metaphor, Performance* (Milton Keynes, Open University, 1998, reprinted 2003) and Rolf Hughes and John Monks, eds, *Hybrid Thought* (Milton Keynes, Open University, 2003).
31. George Steiner, *Real Presences* (London, Faber & Faber, 1989), pp. 55–56.
32. Julie Thompson Klein, 'Interdisciplinarity and complexity: An evolving relationship', *E:CO*, Special Double Issue, Vol. 6, Nos. 1–2 (2004), p. 8.
33. Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations* (Oxford, Blackwell, 1953), #122, 49e.
34. Cited by Ray Monk in *Ludwig Wittgenstein: The Duty of Genius* (New York, Penguin, 1990), p. 357. Monk is quoting from *Wittgenstein's Lectures* by G. E. Moore.
35. Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Culture and Value*, ed., G. H. Von Wright (in collaboration with Heikki Nyman), trs., Peter Winch (Oxford, Basil Blackwell, 1980), 19e.
36. See, for example, Thomas B. Ward, Steven M. Smith, and Jyotsna Vaid, 'Conceptual Structures and Processes in Creative Thought', in Thomas B. Ward, Steven M. Smith and Jyotsna Vaid, eds, *Creative Thought: An Investigation of Conceptual Processes and Structures* (Washington DC, American Psychological Association,1997).
37. Friedrich Schlegel, *Athenaeum*, 77. Cited in N. Santilli, *Such Rare Citings: The Prose Poem in English Literature* (Madison, Fairleigh Dickinson University Press, 2002), p210. Santilli remarks that 'Schlegel uses the garland image to describe a dialogue, the Socratic being the ideal form of criticism for the Romantics.'
38. Fredric Jameson, *The Political Unconscious: Narrative as a Socially Symbolic Act* (Ithaca, Cornell University Press, 1981), p. 106.
39. Jonathan Monroe, 'Introduction: The Prose poem as Dialogical Genre', in *A Poverty of Objects: The Prose Poem and the Politics of Genre* (Ithaca and London, Cornell University Press, 1987), p. 23. Monroe continues: 'Although not all writers have approached literature with equal attention to the fact that forms of *literary* praxis are themselves specific forms of *social* praxis, it is nonetheless true that to choose to write in or on a particular genre is also to choose a particular mode of social, not just narrowly aesthetic intervention. Such a choice inevitably involves a struggle with the resolution of social as well as aesthetic problems that are finally not separate problems at all, even if we often tend to see them as such

because of the reified specializing consciousness capitalism has so contributed to developing.'

40. Wittgenstein. Cited by Ray Monk, *op. cit.*, pp. 364–5.
41. Adam Zagajewski, *Another Beauty*, trs., Clare Cavanagh (New York, Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1998), p. 116. Cited by Jan Zwicky in *Wisdom and Metaphor* (Kentville, Nova Scotia, Gaspereau Press, 2003), p. 108.
42. Osip Mandelstam, 'Conversation about Dante', in Osip Mandelstam, *The Collected Critical Prose and Letters*, trs, Jane Gary Harris and Constance Link, ed., Jane Gary Harris (London, Collins Harvill, 1991), p. 414.
43. *Ibid.*, p. 414.
44. Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Last Writings on the Philosophy of Psychology*, Volume 1, eds, G. H. von Wright and Heikki Nyman, trs, C. G. Luckhardt and Maximilian A. E. Aue (Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 1982),§§ 564–5. There is, of course, a danger in idealising the appeal of 'astonishment' in Wittgenstein's work. There is no virtue in cultivating naivety simply to increase one's capacity for astonishment. Paul Bernays comments: 'The old Greek observation that philosophical contemplation frequently begins in philosophical astonishment today misleads many philosophers into holding the view that the cultivation of astonishment is in itself a philosophical achievement. One may certainly have one's doubts about the soundness of a method which requires young philosophers to be trained as it were in wondering. Wondering is heuristically fruitful only where it is the expression of an instinct of research.' Paul Bernays, 'Comments on Ludwig Wittgenstein's Remarks on the foundations of mathematics', available online at www.phil.cmu.edu/projects/bernays/Pdf/**wittgenstein**.pdf (Accessed 12th June, 2006.)
45. Ludwig Wittgenstein, *On Certainty*, trs, Denis Paul and G.E.M. Anscombe, eds, G.E.M. Anscombe and G.H. von Wright (Oxford, Basil Blackwell, 1979), p. 62e, § 475.
46. See Allan Janik, 'From Logic to Animality or How Wittgenstein Used Otto Weininger', in NÓMADAS, 4 Revista Crítica de Ciencias Sociales y Jurídicas (2001). Available online: http://www.ucm.es/info/nomadas/4/index.html (Accessed 12th June, 2006.)
47. Franz Kafka, trs, Ernst Kaiser and Eithne Wilkins, in Nahum N. Glatzer, ed., *Parables and Paradoxes* (Berlin, Schocken Verlag, 1961), p. 93.
48. Adam Phillips, *Terrors and Experts* (London, Faber & Faber, 1997), p. 68.
49. Katherine Hayles' phrase *orderly disorder* may be one appropriately paradoxical way of describing the complex structure of order and disorder within complex systems wherein tiny deviations can produce radically divergent behaviour. 'Emergence', Hayles writes, 'implies that properties or programs appear on their own, often developing in ways not anticipated by the person who created the simulation. Structures that lead to emergence typically involve complex feedback loops in which the outputs of a system are repeatedly fed back in as input. As the recursive looping continues, small deviations can quickly become magnified, leading to the complex interactions and unpredictable evolutions associated with emergence.' Self-organising, emergent or generative systems do not merely reproduce themselves unchanged—this would be merely the neurotic monotony of repetition—but within them forces of disorder lead to order, and order similarly mutates into disorder at a fundamental level. As Hayles indicates, this implies a *politics of the representation of order* but it also suggests a form of *cyberpoetics* in which noise (defined as the *unexpected*, or in Gregory Bateson's formulation 'any difference that makes a difference') is seen to enhance informational value by resisting information's entropic, homogenising tendency, whereas routine information degenerates into sameness and predictability and thus devalues informational

currency. In other words, innovation is valued and continuity (repetition) devalued, which means that cybernetics and information theory effectively pursue modernist values of originality, individuality, and *making it new.* See Katherine Hayles, *How We Became Posthuman* (London, University of Chicago, 1999), p. 225.

50. Jacques Derrida, 'Force and Signification', in Jacques Derrida, *Writing and Difference*, trs., Alan Bass (London, Routledge, 1978, reprinted 1981), pp. 4–5.
51. See Mikhail Bakhtin, *The Dialogical Imagination: Four Essays by M.M. Bakhtin*, ed., Michael Holquist, trs, Caryl Emerson and Michael Holquist (Austin, Texas, University of Texas Press, 1981).